

The CRM Governance SOP Template

A practitioner checklist for teams who are done with dirty data, broken dashboards, and pipeline numbers that do not match reality.

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Why I built this

I have spent the better part of fifteen years inside marketing ops and RevOps functions at Deloitte, Tesco, Tata, and Godrej. The single most consistent failure I saw was not tool selection. It was governance. Teams would buy Salesforce, HubSpot, or Dynamics, spend six months configuring it, and then watch it degrade within a year because nobody owned the data model, nobody controlled field creation, and nobody could agree on what a 'qualified lead' actually meant.

According to Gartner, poor data quality costs organisations an average of \$12.9 million per year [1]. Forrester research found that 44% of B2B marketers cite data quality as their biggest challenge in personalisation and measurement [2]. These are not abstract statistics. I have seen the exact same problems play out in organisations of 50 people and organisations of 50,000.

This checklist is the operating model I use when I start a CRM governance engagement. It is not exhaustive. It is the minimum you need to stop the bleeding and build something sustainable.

Citations: [1] Gartner, 'How to Stop Data Quality Undermining Your Business,' 2021. [2] Forrester, 'The State of B2B Data,' 2022.

SECTION 1: DATA MODEL AND TAXONOMY

Ownership and definitions

- Define a single owner for each core object (Lead, Contact, Account, Opportunity).
Owner is accountable for field standards, required fields, and data quality within that object.
- Publish a field glossary with approved definitions for all fields used in reporting.
Include: field name, object, definition, who populates it, and acceptable values.
- Agree on a single definition of 'qualified lead' across marketing, sales, and RevOps.
Document the criteria in writing. Store it in the CRM description field and your wiki.
- Set required fields at each lifecycle stage transition.
A lead should not be able to move to MQL without meeting defined criteria.
- Document the naming convention for all custom fields.
Example: [Team]_[Category]_[Descriptor]. Enforce this before any new field is created.

Duplicate and identity management

- Define the primary identifier for deduplication (email, domain, phone, or a combination).

Document the merge rules: which record wins, which fields are preserved.

- Implement a deduplication rule that runs on record creation, not just on import.

Reactive dedup alone will never keep pace with volume.

- Map the identity resolution logic between CRM, MAP, and your finance system.

A customer who exists in three systems needs a consistent identifier in all three.

- Set a deduplication review cadence — at minimum quarterly.

Assign ownership. Without a named owner, this will not happen.

SECTION 2: LIFECYCLE STAGE GOVERNANCE

- Document every lifecycle stage with entry criteria, exit criteria, and SLA.

Entry: what must be true to enter. Exit: what triggers movement to next stage. SLA: how long a record can sit before escalation.

- Implement automated stage-move rules where the criteria are objective.

Manual stage movement is the leading cause of stage drift and reporting unreliability.

- Define what happens to a record when it fails to progress past SLA.

Recycle to nurture, reassign, or disqualify — it must be documented and automated.

- Set up a weekly stage health report showing volume, velocity, and SLA adherence by stage.

This report should go to the revenue leadership team without prompting.

- Define lead routing rules: by geography, segment, account size, product line.

Routing exceptions must also be documented. Unrouted leads are invisible leads.

- Document what happens to leads from events, inbound chat, and partner channels.

These are the most common sources of routing gaps.

SECTION 3: CHANGE CONTROL

This is the section most teams skip. It is also the section whose absence causes the most damage. According to a 2023 survey by Ops-Stars, 67% of RevOps leaders reported that undocumented CRM changes were the primary cause of reporting errors in the previous 12 months [3].

Citation: [3] Ops-Stars, 'State of Revenue Operations,' 2023.

- No new custom field created without a written request stating the business use case.

Include: requestor, use case, reporting dependency, field owner, and approval sign-off.

- All workflow and automation changes logged in a change register before deployment.

Log: change description, expected impact, deployment date, owner, and rollback plan.

- A sandbox environment exists and all changes are tested there before production.

Zero-day production changes are not acceptable for any workflow that touches revenue data.

- A quarterly audit of unused fields, inactive workflows, and orphaned records.

CRM entropy is real. Without scheduled cleanup, debt compounds.

- A named admin who owns the CRM change control process.

This does not have to be a full-time role. It must be a named, accountable person.

- An escalation path for change requests that bypass the standard process.

Executive requests are the most common source of ungoverned changes.

SECTION 4: MEASUREMENT AND REPORTING GOVERNANCE

- Publish a single 'metric definition document' that all teams sign off on.
Include: MQL, SQL, SAL, Opportunity, Win Rate, CAC, LTV, Churn — and the exact CRM logic behind each.
- All executive dashboards source from the same CRM reports, not from manual exports.
If the CEO's pipeline number differs from the CRO's, you have a governance problem, not a data problem.
- Lock the definition of conversion rates — numerator, denominator, time window, filters.
A conversion rate without a locked definition is an opinion.
- Set up a report validation process: at least one person reviews report logic before it goes to leadership.
This takes fifteen minutes and prevents hours of crisis management.
- Finance and CRM pipeline reconciliation happens monthly, not quarterly.
The further apart these reconciliations happen, the larger the discrepancy becomes.
- All attribution rules are documented, versioned, and approved before any model change.
Changing attribution methodology mid-year without documentation makes all historical comparison invalid.

SECTION 5: INTEGRATIONS AND DATA FLOWS

- Document every integration: source system, destination system, sync frequency, and field mapping.
If you cannot draw a data flow diagram in 30 minutes, you do not have enough documentation.
- Identify the system of record for each data type (contact data, account data, deal data).
Two systems cannot both be the source of truth for the same field.
- Set up integration error monitoring with named ownership and response SLA.
Silent sync failures are the most dangerous category of data quality problem.
- All integration changes go through the same change control process as CRM changes.
An undocumented integration change can corrupt months of data before anyone notices.
- Map the data flow from web form to CRM to MAP to finance for at least your top 3 lead sources.
Gaps in this map are where leads disappear without anyone knowing.

What to do next

If you have completed fewer than 60% of this checklist, your CRM is likely costing you revenue through invisible leakage, reporting errors, and team misalignment. The good news is that most of these gaps can be addressed in a structured 8 to 12 week engagement without a full platform replacement.

If you would like to discuss your specific situation, book a diagnostic conversation at consult-ds.com/contact. I personally take the first conversation for all CRM governance enquiries.

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